

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with direct experience advising clients on family, housing, welfare and employment matters at Citizens Advice East Berkshire, supported by a one-year placement at Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner handling complex disputes and arbitration. Experienced in taking client instructions, preparing case files and correspondence, managing deadlines and translating procedural requirements into clear guidance for clients in difficult circumstances. Strong legal research and written communication skills, with a practical grounding in case management, document preparation and hearing support.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit Sept 2024 – Oct 2025

Queen Mary University of London

- Modules in international arbitration, dispute resolution, procedural issues, legal research and evidence analysis
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (data privacy and democracy) — 75%
- Dissertation: data protection and the development of GDPR across jurisdictions

Law LLB — 2:1 Sept 2020 – June 2024

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme in Law and International Relations Sept 2019 – June 2020

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead July 2026 – Present

Legal Adviser

- Advises clients on family, housing, welfare benefits, employment, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements, establishes chronologies and identifies relevant legal and evidential issues
- Manages matters from first instruction through to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Advises clients on procedural requirements and options, translating complex rules into clear, practical guidance for individuals in difficult circumstances
- Assesses eligibility for benefits and support against statutory criteria; identifies evidential gaps and researches complex points of law

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Prepared electronic hearing bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and court materials for active litigation matters
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents across several matters with competing deadlines; maintained matter records via iManage
- Assisted with court filings, hearing arrangements, matter opening and closure, deadline tracking and cost comparisons
- Prepared client attendance notes and matter correspondence

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London
Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial
- Drafted procedural orders and procedural histories; amended sections of the Claimant's memorial; conducted legal research
- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant submission deadline: coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and helped ensure on-time delivery
- Liaised with the client on required documents; coordinated Romanian translations with an external translator
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines
- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Q-Legal · Remote
Legal Adviser

Oct 2024 – Jan 2025

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to formal written advice letter under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations; identified compliance risks and recommended practical mitigations
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with the client and supervising solicitor to meet the agreed deadline

Adobe · London
Legal Intern

June 2022 – Aug 2022

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border data transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries and communicate amendments to stakeholders
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; qualitative client interviewing; document review and analysis; concise report and correspondence writing; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Evidence review, hearing bundle preparation, procedural histories, case-file organisation, deadline tracking, confidential document management